

How To Ethically Engage Fat People in HCI Research

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ABSTRACT

How we research and represent people and communities that may be marginalized or vulnerable is a highly relevant question for our research practices. One particular group that has received some recent attention from HCI and CSCW researchers is fat people and, relatedly, anti-fatness. However, more work is needed to understand how to ethically engage in research with fat people—for example, in studying online communities or designing technology. Toward this goal, we provide a brief introduction to fat people, fat activism, and fat oppression so researchers may understand the social, political, and historical landscape in which research with and about fat people takes place. Based on empirical findings from an interview study, we then provide recommendations for researchers wishing to engage fat people in future research.

CCS CONCEPTS

• **Human-centered computing** → **Human computer interaction (HCI)**; • **Social and professional topics** → **User characteristics**.

KEYWORDS

Marginalized Communities; Research Ethics; Fat; Fat People; Fat Liberation

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1 INTRODUCTION

How researchers ethically engage with marginalized populations, for example in studying online communities or designing new technologies, has inspired a growing body of literature within CSCW and HCI. In her 2014 overview of research ethics and HCI, Bruckman describes the risk of harm to research subjects [5]. More recent

work has focused on risks, challenges, and best practices of HCI research with marginalized people more specifically [25]. Thus far, discussions of these best practices have often concerned questions of who is being researched, by who, and how the research is conducted. For example, there has been an increasing number of discussions about the potential harms of outsiders engaging in research with, about, or on behalf of marginalized people [34, 40]. A key point made by [11, 22, 23] in research around the ethical use of online trace data from marginalized groups is that “marginalization” does not imply the use of monolithic methods. Rather, this body of work suggests that researchers should consider how their research practices should change in consideration of the specific context, history, and needs of any marginalized group. It is with this principle in mind that we attend to the specific ethical requirements when researching fat people.

Recent CSCW and HCI research has explored how anti-fatness arises in technology design and people’s experiences with social media. Prior work by one of the authors investigates how anti-fatness is entangled with other normative assumptions about bodies in technology design [33], as well as how technology design upholds anti-fat beliefs about bodies and health [35]. Other works, such as [12, 16], discuss how anti-fatness shows up in the online experiences of those with eating disorders, with the former calling for future trans-healthcare related research to explore “the impact of fatphobia.” Additionally, the authors of [24] note how anti-fatness is “rampant” in online anti-vax communities. Mack et al. explore the (lack of) disability representation in avatar platforms and include fat people in their study [26]. Finally, [21] specifically investigates experiences of weight stigma on social media and explicitly states their desire to align their work with fat liberation. These studies indicate a growing interest in exploring the experiences of fat people and technology, yet there is virtually no work available on how HCI researchers should ethically engage with fat people or how to think about fat people as a social group in CSCW systems.

To support these efforts, we provide a brief introduction to fat history, fat oppression, and fat liberation, tracing back to the 1973 publication of *The Fat Liberation Manifesto* [14]. We then offer insights from twelve semi-structured interviews with fat people as part of a broader study on fat online communities. We seek to address the following research questions: What concerns do fat people have about technology researchers engaging in research with or about them? What are best practices for researchers engaging in research with or about fat people? Our findings suggest that fat people are “research subjects who care,” [20] and are interested in



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having their experiences with technology, in online communities, and other algorithmic systems documented as a way to account for the epistemic harm fat people face, and as a way to expand the narrow narratives written about fat people.

2 BACKGROUND ON FAT HISTORY, FAT OPPRESSION, AND FAT LIBERATION

Before proceeding, we shed some light on our choice of language. When designing this study, we decided to study "fat people," viewing "fat" as a neutral descriptor. We do not use medicalizing language like "overweight" or "obesity" because, as fat activist Marilyn Wann explains, this "fuels anti-fat prejudice" and "inspires a misplaced search for a 'cure' for naturally occurring difference" [38]. Most of our participants preferred the word "fat," thus we continue to use the term here. Additionally, we describe people who are not fat as "straight-sized" [37]. We also use "anti-fatness" or "fat oppression" instead of "fatphobia" to avoid terminology related to mental illness and call attention to the systemic nature of fat oppression [18].

Fat oppression manifests in a variety of ways. Scholars have shown how fat oppression is historically rooted in white supremacy [19, 36]. Research illustrates that fat oppression shows up in all spheres of life: fat people are denied employment for jobs they are qualified for, denied medical treatment and housing on account of their weight, and fat children are among the most bullied in schools, among others [32, 39]. The medicalization of fatness (and thus, of fat people) is another way in which fat oppression is facilitated [10]. Historically, research about fat people usually prioritizes weight loss at the expense of their own health, safety, and dignity. For example, a study made international headlines in 2021 when researchers published about a "weight loss device" which would wire fat people's jaws shut for two weeks to "help" them lose weight [1, 2]. As fat activist and scholar Rachel Fox points out, the dominance of "obesity epidemic" discourses, as legitimated by academic institutions, has narrowed both what is known — and considered important to know — about fat people [13]. As a consequence, fat people both within and outside of academia face widespread testimonial injustice [15], where they are not seen as credible experts on their own experience.

To provide some historical context, fat activism is often traced back to the 1960s with the formation of groups like the National Association for the Advancement of Fat Acceptance, or the 1973 publication of The Fat Underground's *The Fat Liberation Manifesto*. [14, 38]. Fat Studies, the academic field concerned with the experiences of fat people, the ways in which fat oppression operates, and advocating for more liberatory knowledge production, emerged a while later. While these groups vary in specific goals and strategies, they broadly work toward the goal of *fat liberation* or a world where fat people have equal access to all aspects of society. Note: fat liberation is distinct from body positivity, which focuses on improving a person's internal experience of their body. While individually rewarding, fat scholars and activists suggest that body positivity does not address the material, systemic discrimination fat people face [8].

3 METHOD

We conducted twelve semi-structured, 90-minute interviews. Participants had to identify as fat, speak English or German, and be at least 18 years of age. These interviews are part of a larger study related to fat people's experiences in online communities, and as such, participants were recruited through social media posts on Twitter, Facebook, Instagram, and Tumblr. The entire interview protocol consisted of questions relating to the participants' relationship with fatness, participation in online communities, and questions about research ethics, based on Klassen and Fiesler's prior work on research ethics with respect to Black Twitter [23]. Given the interview's main focus on participation in online communities, many of our initial questions about research ethics related to researchers' use of online trace data. However, many participants emphasized other concerns, reflected in our discussion below.

The first two authors conducted the interviews and the majority of the analysis. Regarding the entire research team, a subset of us identify as fat. We also hold other marginalized identities that shape our research. Moreover, all of the authors are white, which we note given our findings as well as discussions from Pausé and Taylor. These authors suggest that the whiteness of fat scholarship — both in participants and researchers involved — often threatens the goals of such work because anti-Blackness and other colonial pursuits are intertwined with anti-fatness [29].

Drawing from Braun and Clarke [3, 4], themes were produced via qualitative thematic analysis. The first two authors engaged in open coding followed by iterative affinity diagramming. Potential themes were discussed, often rooted in theories from fat studies, such as fat epistemology, and previous HCI research ethics work. Quotes presented below have been edited for concision, but the meanings have not been changed.

Regarding demographics, the only information we required participants to share with us was the inclusion criteria mentioned above. For other aspects of identity, we let participants share with us what they felt was relevant throughout the interview. The majority of our participants were white, queer women. Two participants were people of color, a Black trans genderqueer artist as well as an Indigenous, non-binary woman from the American southwest. Participants further described themselves as trans-masc, disabled, chronically ill, neurodivergent, young, menopausal, or Jewish.

4 RESULTS AND DISCUSSION

In this section, we outline the themes we identified from our interviews. We then make recommendations to researchers for specific actions they should take when working with fat participants.

4.1 Choose Respectful Language

Although our inclusion criteria required participants to identify as fat, we recognize people have different and complicated relationships with the term. Drawing on recommendations from fat studies scholarship around self-disclosure, we began each interview by asking participants what language they use to describe themselves [7]. Most referred to themselves as fat but some expressed reticence over using the label. For example, P1 shared that they most often use "overweight" because "fat" is often intended as an "insult," but it is "absolutely fine" to use it in our study.

Those who do identify as fat described why they prefer “fat” over medicalizing language or euphemisms. For example, P6 said about BMI¹-based language such as “overweight” or “obesity” that “it feels pathologizing, it feels like they’re looking at me and going, you’re not a human, you’re a condition.” Throughout the interviews, multiple participants (P0, P1, P3, P7, P6, P9, and P11) offered critiques of using the BMI, ranging from its roots in white supremacy, inability to provide accurate health insights, or basis for discrimination (cf., [36]). In fact, P11 was interested in participating in our study because she “thought it was cool” that, rather than using BMI, “you’re just talking to us like we’re people and not numbers.” P8 elaborated on the way that euphemisms feel “condescending” and try to make being fat “seem better,” but in fact promote stigma. She shared that the use of euphemisms is “not to make me feel better” but “to make other people feel better.” P9 agreed that using the word “fat” is preferable to “beating around the bush,” and talked about “re-claiming” the word. These concerns echo prior CSCW work which highlights the important distinction between how people classify themselves and are classified by others [31].

When asked what language researchers should use, participants agreed, regardless of their own preferred terminology, that researchers should follow the lead of their participants. P7 stated, “I’ve always been kind of, uh, resentful toward people deciding who I am for me.” P9 offered the following example, “I think it’s really important to consider how people identify and like what language they like to use. If [a participant] preferred the word curvy, then [in] all of the questions about fatness, you [the interviewer] would use the word curvy.”

To this end, we recommend that researchers: (1) Ask participants what language they use to describe themselves, and use this language when interacting with them and reporting about them. And (2), consider the connotation of the language that you are using. All language, including increasingly popular euphemisms such as “person of size” or “people in larger bodies” as well as medicalizing language, such as “obesity” or “overweight” are value-laden. Based on scholarship from fat studies scholars and fat activists, at this point, the author team recommends “fat” as the best default term for HCI scholars to use until the participants or context indicates otherwise.

4.2 Consider Positionality and Practice Reflexivity

The question of who should engage in research with or about fat people was a recurring theme across interviews. Similar to [11, 23], many participants voiced discomfort around outsiders conducting research. P2 described past harms where “people who weren’t a part of this community” conducted research that “reifies some concept that somebody already had.” P1 touched on the comfort of sharing identities with researchers, saying, “when you [the researcher] came on [the Zoom video conference] and you know, you’re a fat person, that’s reassuring.” P6, however, discussed how outsiders can be allies if they mindfully leveraged their privilege: “One point is, it’s really great to have allies who are thin or even just people who are smaller fats than you are. Because the smaller you are, the

more privilege you have. At the same time, it’s really frustrating that people will only listen to the privileged people.”

For many participants, “outsider” and “insider” status is not as simple as “fat” or “straight-sized.” As P6 mentioned above, “smaller fats” have more privilege than large fat people, and may not share similar experiences [17]. P1, P5, and P10 similarly discussed outsiders in terms of intersecting identities. For example, P5 told us: “I think a lot of stuff is written from the perspective of white women. And I don’t know if I want to read those because I don’t identify as strongly with white people as I do with people of color, because we just have different experiences.”

Researchers’ intentions equally mattered to participants. P1 expressed disdain for researchers who engage with fat people as “just something that people are doing to advance their career.” Others, like P3, were concerned about harmful intentions. When asked about researchers’ use of social media data, P3 said: “If the researcher is just interested in understanding how communities function or something, I’m fine with that. I guess all Twitter data is open to the public to use however they want. If the researcher hates fat people and wants to set out to paint fat people in a bad light, then I would be opposed to that research.” P3 went on to say, “I think the place of academic research, and especially medical research, is that they need to start undoing the harm they’ve done.”

This harm, unintentional or not, was underscored by participants’ concerns about who gets deemed an expert on fatness. Multiple participants discussed the testimonial injustice fat people face in contrast to the perceived legitimacy and authority of academic research institutions. P9 stated, “[Knowledge about fat people is] definitely seen as more legitimate if it’s in an academic book... Whereas people who are talking about their lived experience online are not necessarily as legitimate.”

Based on these comments, we make the following recommendations to researchers: (1) Like all marginalized groups of people, fat people are not a monolith, and should not be expected to act as one. Fat people’s experiences vary greatly across the spectrum of size and intersecting identities. Researchers should consider this diversity when thinking about their own position relative to participants’, when analyzing data, and reviewing works about fat people. (2) Engage with the history of fat oppression, especially as facilitated by academic research and medical institutions. We recommend [13, 19, 30] as primers. (3) Given the history of testimonial injustice leveraged against fat people, we encourage researchers to become familiar with fat epistemology, or the idea that fat people should be regarded as immediate knowers about fat experiences and should drive knowledge production on fatness [9, 27, 28]. Fat epistemology can inform research agendas as well as collaborations - fat researchers should be included and funded on these projects.

4.3 Rethink Assumptions Around Weight Loss

The most resounding recommendation we heard from participants is that researchers should not make “assumptions about health” or assume “fat people should or want to lose weight.” (P9) Participants were particularly concerned about how these assumptions related to the research and design of “health” applications, noting that the definition of “health” in a variety of technologies is defined by lower body weight. P2 shared, “I think that there are a lot of

¹BMI refers to Body Mass Index, a calculation measurement based on body weight and height.

applications for monitoring health that if they weren't focused on weight loss could do a lot of good and be of a lot of use. But since I already know what their idea of health is, I'm not really inclined." P7 discussed how these assumptions limit the kinds of knowledge produced about fat people: "I think that that assumption just kind of bars the researcher from very interesting and insightful research, cause maybe they'll find people who are genuinely happy with who they are."

Participants also discussed frustration with weight loss technology being the primary area of technology innovation for fat people. For example, P2 said, "I think that if they weren't trying to punish us for being fat, if they weren't trying to shame us for being fat, and if we weren't expected to need to suffer more, there would be more catering to us." P2 suggests that designers expect fat people to change, rather than designing for them as they are: "If it doesn't make your life better, you should make yourself thinner so that it affects you; we don't have to make anything for you."

While most participants were opposed to assumptions that fat people would want to lose weight, some participants were still invested in weight loss, such as P7 and P11. Fat people are neither monolithically against nor in favor of intentional weight loss. **Given this, we caution researchers as follows:** (1) Don't make assumptions about fat people's health or assume that all fat people want to lose weight. (2) Do consider how "weight loss" may be embedded as a value in the design of technology and the negative impacts this value might have on fat people. (3) Do consider definitions of health that are not weight-centric, such as the Health at Every Size paradigm [6].

4.4 Engage Fat People in Research

Paralleling participants' desire to decenter weight loss as the locus of technology research for fat people, many participants discussed their hopes for future fat research. P2, P4, P8, and P10 discussed the lack of representation of fat people in non-medical research as their motivation for participating in our study. P8 said, "Anything that clears that [erasure] up, I'm going to support." P10 connected this to testimonial injustice fat people face: "Just how often do people ask fat people what they need or want and we get to express ourselves instead of having somebody else talk for us?"

Participants connected this lack of representation to the methods researchers should use. P2 said researchers should, "search fat people out" and P9 emphasized the importance of capturing the fullness of fat people's experiences through qualitative methods: "Often when people are talking about their lived experience, that's really important to listen to and that's really valuable information. Especially as a qualitative researcher, like lived experience is so important to hear about, I guess, and see as legitimate."

P9 spoke optimistically about future research, commenting, "There's so much I feel like hasn't been talked about yet. Within social media and all the different communities that are formed, the way people learn from social media, that's just one aspect. There's almost an infinite amount of things that haven't even been talked about yet." P8 noted that she would like to see less research around deficit narratives, and instead, "I would really like to see more and find more information and more people talking about thriving as being a fat person and celebrating the good things that happen."

Based on these discussions, we recommend the following:

Engage fat people in research on technology and choose projects, research questions, and methods that center fat people's voices, needs, and desires. Possible research questions might consider the experiences fat people have with everyday technologies, beyond weight loss. Methods might include participatory processes or futuring.

5 CONCLUSION

"We believe fat people are fully entitled to human respect and recognition... We see our struggle as allied with the struggles of other groups against classism, racism, sexism, ageism, financial exploitation, imperialism, and the like." – The Fat Liberation Manifesto

There is growing interest in the HCI community around fat people, anti-fatness, and technology. We hope our work provides an opening to help researchers more ethically engage with fat people and work toward the goal of fat liberation — which, as the "The Fat Liberation Manifesto" points out, is entangled with a broader project of co-liberation. However, we have only scratched the surface. Future work on research with fat people should look specifically at attitudes toward the use of online trace data. We also recognize the need for further research that centers the experiences of fat BIPOC people. Moreover, decades of history and scholarship about a marginalized group cannot be captured in a brief poster. Therefore, we invite researchers to read from fat activists and scholars [13]. Finally, while there is increasing attention to how to ethically conduct research with and about marginalized people writ large, another implication of our work is the need for more research on how to ethically engage in research with specific marginalized groups, and their intersections.

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